PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #68 · ABUSE

“I have to keep them calm. If they get angry, it is my job to fix it.”

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Where it often comes from

If someone’s anger was dangerous, you may have learned to watch their face and smooth every wave. Keeping them calm felt like keeping yourself, or the children, alive. That skill was survival. The lie says their feelings are your job, and that if they get angry, you failed and you caused the harm. You are not the manager of another adult’s emotions. You are allowed to be a person, not a shock absorber. If their anger is still dangerous, the next step is safety, not better calming. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

The Lord is on your side. You do not have to be afraid of a human being as if their mood were your god. “Do not fear, for I am with you.” God is a refuge. Jesus gives peace that is not the same as a house where everyone must stay pleasant. We carry one another’s burdens, which is mutual care, not one person preventing another’s anger at all costs. Their anger is theirs. Your safety matters.

> *“The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?”* (Psalm 118:6).

Also see

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

> “God is our refuge and strength, an ever-present help in times of trouble” (Psalm 46:1).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- If I say the wrong thing, it is my fault when they explode.
- A good partner, child, or Christian keeps them calm.
- I have to read the room or someone gets hurt.
- My needs make them angry, so my needs are the problem.
- If I were better, they would be peaceful.
- Leaving would be cruel because they need me to regulate them.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Making their emotion your responsibility and your fault.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling dread and concluding you must fix their mood.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either you keep them calm or you are to blame for harm.
- Fortune telling: Deciding that any honesty will certainly cause an explosion you must prevent.

Challenging questions

- Whose feeling is this, and who is making me carry it?
- What happens to me when I spend the day preventing their anger?
- Would I tell a friend it was their job to keep someone else calm?
- Is soothing them keeping me safe, or only postponing harm?
- What would one honest sentence cost, and do I have a safety plan?
- What does "the Lord is on my side" free me from managing?

Truth summary

> Their feelings are not my job. I am not the cause of their anger, and I am allowed to be safe instead of keeping them calm.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Anxiety/Worry
- Trust
- Help
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Love
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Whom Shall I Fear — Chris Tomlin
You do not have to manage another person's anger in order to be safe with God.

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
Their mood is not a battle you are required to win.

Same Power — Jeremy Camp
God's strength is for you, not for keeping someone else from ever being upset.

Because He Lives — Bill and Gloria Gaither
You can face a hard moment without appointing yourself their emotional guard.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I have to keep them calm. If they get angry, it is my job to fix it."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to keep them calm. If they get angry, it is my job to fix it." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose feeling is this, and who is making me carry it?
- ☐ What happens to me when I spend the day preventing their anger?
- ☐ Would I tell a friend it was their job to keep someone else calm?
- ☐ Is soothing them keeping me safe, or only postponing harm?
- ☐ What would one honest sentence cost, and do I have a safety plan?
- ☐ What does "the Lord is on my side" free me from managing?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Their feelings are not my job. I am not the cause of their anger, and I am allowed to be safe instead of keeping them calm.
- ☐ I can care without managing another adult's emotions.
- ☐ Their anger is not automatically my fault.
- ☐ Keeping the peace is not the same as being safe.
- ☐ God is on my side. I am not alone with their mood.
- ☐ I can say no without being responsible for their reaction.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 118:6
  "The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?"
- ☐ Isaiah 41:10
  "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness."
- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you rushed to keep someone calm: Each day, write down one moment when their mood felt like your fault to prevent. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 118:6 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is on my side. I do not have to manage their anger to be safe.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Fear" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- [ ] Pause one fix. The next time you start to smooth their mood, wait ten seconds if it is safe, and notice that their feeling is still theirs.
- [ ] Make a safety plan with your counselor or with 1-800-799-7233 if their anger is dangerous. Do not experiment with honesty that could put you in danger.
- [ ] Write "not my job" on a card you can see. Their emotion is on one side. Your safety is on the other.
- [ ] Tell your counselor how much of the day you spend preventing someone's anger.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to keep them calm. If they get angry, it is my job to fix it.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment their feeling was not my job
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to keep them calm. If they get angry, it is my job to fix it~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have lived as the one who must keep them calm. You are on my side. Free me from carrying their anger, and show me the safe next step. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.